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Review

Reviewed Work(s): *Marvelous Possessions: The Wonder of the New World*. by Stephen Greenblatt

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Stephen Greenblatt. *Marvelous Possessions: The Wonder of the New World*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991. ix + 202 pp. \$24.95.

The experience of wonder is, as Stephen Greenblatt so richly documents in his recent work, *Marvelous Possessions*, at once a powerful experience and, perhaps surprisingly, an ideologically neutral one. For what wonder registers is the shock of unexpected access to a reality that decenters and subsumes what is previously accepted as the real; it marks the sudden awareness of one's participation in a greater whole, a whole that can only be glimpsed through the fragmentary encounter with otherness.

Marvelous Possessions documents some of the many variations of wonder as it was given expression in discovery narratives of early-modern Europeans: in the writings of Mandeville, Columbus, Fro-bisher, Montaigne, among others. The central aim of the study is to render legible the "European discourse of wonder" (132) as this derived specifically from the encounter with alien cultures of the New World and was first marked in the exchanges through which intercultural contact was made. In focusing on wonder, Greenblatt seeks to side-step the reductive trap of viewing Europe's "discovery" of the Americas as simply about conquest and colonization. For even as the encounter with the other is immediately caught up in the "representational machinery" (120) of the new colonial powers and their drive to possess the marvels they find, this encounter can also lead, as Greenblatt notes, "precisely to a sense of dispossession, . . . a self-estrangement in the face of the strangeness, diversity, and opacity of the world" (74). What the study offers then is insight into what the monumental shock of the unfamiliar meant to the Europeans as well as the representational strategies that were employed to contain it and those new strategies of understanding which the shock engendered.

Despite this commitment to seeing wonder as a diverse experience, however, Greenblatt is most interested in those aspects of wonder that actually prohibit anything like true cultural exchange; hence, the study is in fundamental ways indistinguishable from other post-colonial studies of the subject (including his own earlier work). Greenblatt's energies are still directed toward unveiling the most brutal aspects of the encounters: the acts of dispossession perpetrated by the Europeans upon the unsuspecting natives, the kid-

nappings, the massacres, the insane and incredible moments of hypocrisy. While one can hardly disagree with this approach on moral and political grounds, it does leave the impression that Greenblatt is simply rounding up the usual suspects in yet another example of an arrogant modern effort to chastise the past. Greenblatt avoids the worst excesses of this kind of critique through a careful selection and pairing of the details by which he constructs his argument. Displaying the full range of his skills as a storyteller, Greenblatt strings together narrative moments in such a compelling way that the familiar account he gives takes on a certain novelty; indeed, the narrative has a wondrousness of its own: strange, lyrical, grand, tragic. At the same time, his willingness to link these moments together through critical commonplaces makes one feel that expert storytelling is all Greenblatt can really offer.

Greenblatt might counter that story-telling should be enough. For, in a study filled with moments of ambivalence, the one certainty derives from an appreciation of the importance of stories as sites of moral imagination, spaces of interchange where we can come to discover both ourselves in the other and the other in ourselves. Framing his narrative with discussions of that self-estranging wonder that resists either obliterating or appropriating alien cultures, Greenblatt seems finally to want to reclaim for wonder its innocence. It is an innocence he seems desperately to desire for his own critical work as well.

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Alan Sinfield. *Faultlines: Cultural Materialism and the Politics of Dissident Reading*. Berkeley, Los Angeles and Oxford: University of California Press, 1992. xii + 365 pp. \$50 cloth; \$19 paper.

Imaginative writing has a place, major or minor, in a culture when it fits and is interpreted to fit the dominant ideology of that culture. It fits and helps compose, that is to say, the form and arguments of knowledge and belief that structure the relations of power organizing the culture and benefitting the elites whose interests they chiefly serve. "The principle strategy of ideology is to legitimate inequality and exploitation by representing the social order that perpetuates these things as immutable and unalterable—as decreed by God or simply natural" (114). However, where